

Mary, Star of the Sea School Mission

Nurture, Unite, Inspire. We are committed to nurturing each child's curiosity, uniting our classroom in respect and collaboration, and inspiring every student to grow in knowledge, faith, and wonder for the world around them.

Essential Question

"How can I model kindness, fairness, and humility like Jesus?"

Nicolle Bekers, M.A.

Intermediate Team Faculty · Grade 4 · SY 2026-2027

Email: nbekers@starofthesea.org

All 4th Grade Teachers: 4thgradeteachers@starofthesea.org

Phone: 808-734-0208 · **Office Hours:** 2:45-3:15 p.m. (M-F) in Room B23

Address: 4469 Malia Street, Honolulu, Hawai'i 96821

Welcome

Welcome to Grade 4! I am excited to partner with you this school year. This syllabus provides an outline of what we will learn, classroom expectations, grading policies, and the support you can expect throughout the school year. We will work together to create a class community where every student is encouraged, challenged, and inspired to grow academically and spiritually.

Schoolwide Learning Expectations (SLEs): Self-Aware, Confident Individuals;

Teachable Life-Long Learners; Active Christians; Responsible Citizens.

English Language Arts Course Overview

This course focuses on developing **reading, writing, speaking, and listening skills**. Students engage with classic and modern literature, explore grammar and vocabulary, and practice various forms of writing. Our primary focus is that every student develops a love for — and grade-level understanding of — books, writing, language, and grammar.

Standardized testing: Students take the **STAR** assessment in fall, winter, and spring to track growth. English-language learners take the **WIDA** assessment as required.

Core Texts / Novels

Wonder
R.J. Palacio
The Tale of Despereaux
Kate DiCamillo
Inside Out and Back Again
Thanhha Lai
Holes
Louis Sachar

English Grading Policy

30%AssessmentsOral / written tests and quizzes

25%ClassworkDaily reading & writing practice

20%Writing PortfolioPublished pieces & drafts

15%Participation / HWNovel discussion, reading log

10%Projects & Presentations

Parents, please note: You will have access to my electronic grade book via your **Beehively** account, which will be the method of communicating your child's academic performance. Beehively will serve as the primary source for monitoring grades, missing assignments, and academic progress throughout the school year.

Parent-teacher conferences: Formal conferences are held after Q1 and Q3

grades post. Additional conferences may be requested by email anytime.

Required Materials

Students should bring the following materials to English each day:

- Composition or spiral notebook (Reader's / Writer's Notebook)
- Erasable pen, pencil, eraser and highlighter
- Sticky notes for annotating novels

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- School-issued iPad (with access to Google Classroom)
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- School planner

Supplemental Materials — Core novels: *Wonder, The Tale of Despereaux,*

Inside Out and Back Again, Holes

Daily Schedule

Please refer to the MSOS Grade 4 daily bell schedule (a hard copy is included in your first-week folder) for exact times. Specials (P.E., Music, Art, Library, and Chapel) rotate on specific days — please check the weekly schedule sent home.

Pickup procedures and any late-start / early-release days are in the family handbook and the school calendar.

Homework Policy

As per school policy, students are expected to allocate time for a maximum of **40 minutes of homework per night** (MSOS guideline: ~10 minutes per grade). Your

child's 4th grade teachers work together to ensure a balanced homework regime.

Students record assignments in their planner. Homework and reminders are also posted on Google Classroom.

Late work will be accepted; however, submitting on time is important for developing responsibility. Late submissions may affect the participation grade.

Tips for supporting homework at home:

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- Set a consistent, quiet study time and place.
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- Read directions together, then step back and let your child try.
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- Ask your child to explain the story or writing back to you — teaching cements learning.
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- If a task takes much longer than expected, please note it and email me.

Classroom Procedures & Behavior Expectations

- Students come to class prepared and ready to learn each day.
- Homework should be completed on time. If circumstances prevent completion, students should communicate with the teacher in advance so an appropriate plan can be made.
- Everyone is encouraged to participate by asking questions, contributing ideas, and seeking clarification.
- We will treat ourselves, one another, and school property with respect and responsibility.

Positive recognition: Students earn recognition through verbal praise, positive notes home, sticker/star acknowledgments, and class-wide rewards (extra recess, class read-aloud pick, review-day celebrations).

When expectations are not met (supportive, restorative sequence):

- 1. Quiet private reminder and reset.

2. Reflection sheet / think-time in class.

3. Loss of a small privilege and a note home.

4. Phone call or email home; if needed, a family meeting with the principal.

The goal is always to help students re-choose kind, respectful, on-task behavior —
not to punish.

Room Parent & Parent Volunteers

Ways to help: chaperoning field trips, class parties (Halloween, Christmas,

Valentine's, end-of-year), guest-reading a favorite book, sharing your job or hobby,

and providing occasional classroom supplies.

How to sign up: Please email me if you'd like to help — I'll connect you with our

room parent. **All volunteers must have current safe-environment training on**

file with the school office before helping in the classroom or on field trips.

Key dates to remember: Back-to-School Night, Parent-Teacher Conferences (Q1 & Q3), All Saints Prayer Service, Christmas Program, Catholic Schools Week, STEM Fair, Field Day, and end-of-year Awards.

How to Support Your Child at Home

- **Routines:** Build a consistent homework/reading time and a distraction-free spot.
- **Read together nightly** (20+ minutes). Ask what your child noticed, wondered, and predicted.
- **Independence:** Let your child pack their own backpack and check the assignment sheet — mistakes are how we learn.
- **Growth mindset:** Praise effort and strategy (“I saw you keep trying”) more than just results.
- **Communication:** Check Beehively weekly with your student. Celebrate wins and unpack misses together.

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- **Real-world literacy:** Point out language and word roots in menus, signs, and family conversations.
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- **Contact me early** if something at home or school is affecting learning.
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Important Dates • 2026–2027

Parent Orientation Night	August 12, 2026
Parent-Teacher Conferences	Fall — Sept. 10–11, 2026 · Spring — Feb. 19, 2027 (optional)
Q1 Expedition — Coconut Island	October 2, 2026
Q2 Expedition — Pearl Harbor (pending)	November 16, 2026
Q2 Expedition — Ice Palace	December 14, 2026
Q3 Expedition — ‘Iolani Palace	March 5, 2027
Q4 Expedition — Sherwood Forest (pending)	June 1, 2027
School Spelling Bee	November 20, 2026
Christmas Performance	December 18, 2026
End-of-Year Awards	June 3, 2027

**All expeditions are subject to change at this point in the school year :)*

Academic Integrity

Teachers structure conditions during testing to alleviate the possibility of cheating;

specify allowed collaboration; and teach summarization vs. copying.

Students avoid situations that might contribute to cheating or plagiarizing, avoid

unauthorized assistance, and use sources in the prescribed manner.

Absences & Tardiness

Students may remain at home in the case of illness, accident, quarantine, or a

death in the family. For prolonged absences, families must notify the teacher so a

plan can be developed.

Students are marked **tardy after the 7:45 a.m. bell**. Explanatory notes from

parents may be advisable.

Food & Drink

- Food is prohibited in the classroom unless otherwise specified by the teacher.

- Drink in the classroom is limited to water in a bottle with a sealed lid.
- Sharing food is not permitted to ensure adherence to dietary restrictions.

Technology

To minimize distractions and maximize learning, communication with students during the school day should be limited to emergencies. Student cell phones must remain off and in backpacks (this policy also applies to smart watches).

Violations: 1st — Warning; 2nd — Phone sent to office for pickup from Principal;

3rd — Phone sent to office and parent notified.

Teacher Contact

Mrs. Nicole Bekers, M.A. — Intermediate Team Faculty

✉ nbekers@starofthesea.org — please allow up to 24 hours for a response on school days.

✉ 4th Grade Team: 4thgradeteachers@starofthesea.org

☐ Office phone: 808-734-0208

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☐ Mary, Star of the Sea School, 4469 Malia Street, Honolulu, Hawai'i 96821

Final Notes & Parent Acknowledgment

Thank you for partnering with me this year. Your support at home is the single biggest factor in your child's confidence and success in English. I am grateful for the trust you place in Mary, Star of the Sea and in this classroom.

Class website: starofthesea.org/classes

Parent Acknowledgment: After reviewing this syllabus with your student, please email nbekers@starofthesea.org with the subject line "Grade 4 English Syllabus

Reviewed — [Student Name]" so I know it has reached your family. Mahalo!

Empowered to Succeed, Guided by Faith ♥!